



BWNA General Meeting Minutes

August 10, 2026

Sylvan Learning Center: 4300 N.E. Fremont St

7:00 pm to 8:30 pm

Roll Call & Introductions (President Al Ellis presiding)

Board Roll Call:

- Attending: Al Ellis, President; Tim Gillespie, Vice-President; Patty Nelson, Immediate Past President. At Large Members: Susan Trabucco, Colin O'Neil, John Sandie, Tom Cuppernull, Crystal Grainger.
- Excused Absence: Patti Koehler, Secretary; Karla Lenox, Treasurer. At Large Members: Tim Root, Angela Frome, Aaron Breakstone, David Knowles, Rob Lee.

Guests: Elana Pirtle-Guiney, District 2 City Councilor; Faisel Osman, Outreach and Engagement Advisor for Councilor Pirtle-Guiney.

Non-Board Members Attending:

- Committee Chairs: Graeme Rudd, Transportation Committee; Steven Avery, Communications Committee.
- In Person: Matt Grainger, Peggy Ellis, George Chen, Barbara Davis, Jim Karlock, Kathy Fritts, Walter Bibb, Peggie Page, Deb Harris, Michael Taylor.
- On-line: Stephanie Wahab, Kimberly Solvedt, Kate Daameron, Lori Vance, Jackie, Steven.

Meeting Agenda Review: Motion to approve agenda made by Susan T. and seconded by Tim G. Passed unanimously.

SPEAKER: ELANA PIRTLE-GUINEY

"Thank you for invite. Nice to get out of city hall and hear what's on your mind and what we need to pay more attention to. You have three District 2 City Councilors: Sameer Kanal, Dan Ryan and me. We work together on issues that affect the district. While we are all different in how we approach council and the values we hold, we come together to support neighborhoods and coordinate to have a united front for District 2.

"My background is advocacy and policy working with non-profits and at the state level.

"I am the chair of the City Life Committee. We focus on everything the city wants the city to do that doesn't have resources: work force and labor development, equity, arts, culture, sports, business and economic development. We consider the lived experience in Portland and what we want to see 20 years from now. I am one of the only city councilors who has young children and can bring that lived experience – considering transportation and parks--to inform and learn from. We live in a socio-economically diverse district.

"What questions do you have for me?"

Q1: Is Civic Life still in charge of overseeing our District 2 Coalition Office (DCO)? Who on council oversees it? The Committee of the Whole or the Office of Community & Civic Life?

A1: Pirtle-Guiney said that direct oversight is by the City Administrator and Mayor, with Council providing accountability oversight. Adam Lyons is the city's liaison for district coalitions, operating as project manager over their contracts.

Al Ellis mentioned that at the October 12th BWNA meeting, NECN District 2 Coalition Office Executive Director, Jona Davis will be our guest speaker.

Q2: Lori Vance (via Zoom) shared concerns about recent car thefts. She operates a business near 50th and Fremont, in a mixed-use building with apartments and businesses. She reported recent car thefts to BBA and BWNA. A couple of weeks ago – two tenants had cameras – each of them had a car stolen during night. Police were called. One got their car back. One tenant moved out. Cameras have been installed on back of building.

A1: Pirtle-Guiney added that we need to focus on enforcing the laws – so there are consequences for actions. There is not enough staff to do this but the city is working to build up support, seeking to see improvement over the next year. A challenge is the budget scaled back the Public Safety Support Specialist (PS3) positions. The PS3's respond to non-emergency calls, taking reports and following up when police are too busy. She received word from PS3 that they are operating at the minimum now.

Discussion: Tom Cuppernull added that his home was burglarized after his co-worker's car was stolen two weeks ago. His camera's captured the thieves and he worked with two detectives on property crimes, successfully tracking down his stolen bike. Graeme mentioned he would work with transportation committee to find ways to work with councilors. Jim Karlock mentioned shortage of police is a common theme and expressed concerns with council priorities of funding Moda Center improvements over staffing for police.

~~Council Pirtle-Guiney:~~ Regarding Moda Center Updates, Councilor Pirtle-Guiney shared background on the issue as well as options she sees for consideration. The city purchased the Moda Center from Paul Allen for \$1 and owns the facility. In speaking with the users of the Moda Center, it does not meet the need for a contemporary arena. There are concerts that can't perform there due to limitations of the structure to support their needs. There are tournaments and big events that have expectations for how facilities work, and the Moda center doesn't meet those. As an example, the NCAA is coming in a couple years – they will need green rooms for half-time shows. Currently the

Moda Center can only offer curtained-off spaces. Operational efficiencies are also a consideration. The people who work there make it work, but staff and time requirements to transition from event to event are challenging: floors need to be changed out, chairs need to be physically pushed back to make more room, etc. Newer automated features can make these transitions quicker, meaning shorter down times between events. Handicapped accessibility is also a challenge, with only one public accessible elevator. The reality is we will be able to host fewer and fewer events if improvements aren't made to the arena.

Pirtle-Guiney sees 3 options for the Moda Center:

- Option 1: Deal with Blazers: So far, the new owner has been challenging. Funding is available to support a deal from state and county governments, as partners.
- Option 2: Make improvements w/o Blazers: This would allow the arena to host more events, but would limit funding sources to the city (no county or state contributions). The benefit: increased revenue potential from more tournaments and concerts.
- Option 3: Do Nothing: Declining revenue over time would make it harder and harder to fund needed improvements. Equity concerns this land was historically taken from families (primarily Black residents) for development. The Albina Land Trust is trying to bring residents and wealth back to the neighborhood, and doing nothing would be walking away and leaving a whole hole there.

Q3: Michael Taylor expressed concern about the process of the renaming of Cesar Chavez Ave. process, proceeding outside the established process and marginalizing public input.

The Councilor noted that there are six councilors who live in districts that the street passes through, but she is the only one knocking on doors. The renaming discussion has been pulled from the Planning Commission, which has created frustration. Now the decision will go to city council. While it is not a full engagement process, the public can provide comments at city council. Council has been having conversations but there is currently no unanimous perspective.

The process for renaming streets has received complaints, due to the difficulty in the process. The streamlined approach being taken, however, cuts out engagement of community, businesses, and neighborhood associations. The hope is to improve the process in the future.

Q4: Susan Trabucco: Inner East Side for All – she understands the study period is being extended to 2028. She doesn't want to be a NIMBY but does have concerns about what this proposal looks like. Additional housing with full transportation capabilities is important, but this proposal could mean high rises on Alameda Ridge and increased parking pressure on streets – not near transit.

Pirtle-Guiney said the plan is to have the study complete by June 2027 not 2028. It is a huge process. We need more space for people to live. The idea of our central city needs to expand beyond the downtown, more than it has. In this new density expansion area, we need to determine whether it means density everywhere or along more main corridors than we have in the past and which ones. We have main streets approximately every 5 blocks on the eastside. Do we focus on those streets? Do we have squares of denser development? Do we have increased density through-out the eastside? None of this proposal requires change and it would not occur immediately.

Discussion:

- Deb Harris– What is the justification for density – people are moving out. High vacancies exist in apartments.

The Councilor responded that density is the best way to support affordability – more supply equals lower prices. Density is also needed to accommodate growth from climate and political refugees over the next 10 to 20 years. We are a growing region and living through change. We are moving from small town feel to a denser city. Once that change happens – new Portland – people will love it. People living through it won't. While vacancies exist now, we will need more housing in the future. Parking issues will create more demand for public transit which will result in needed investment.

- Patty Nelson – Having worked on the city's Big Pipe project, this resident knows the city spent billions of dollars to control sewer overflows to the river. Evaluation of impacts on proposed increased density and lot coverage on underground public utilities needs to be a consideration, as there may be significant impacts to these systems resulting in increased public cost or consequences, such as increased overflows to the river.

Q5: Stephanie Wahab: Live on 44th – question about the plaza and public input. The plaza has had a negative impact on residents. How are the needs and concerns of those who are most impacted by the plaza addressed? They have voiced concerns to BBA, BWNA and PBOT but those organizations seemed committed to making the plaza happen, regardless of and at the expense of the residents. Where can neighbors go to be heard?

Al Ellis Response: Public meetings were held, concerns heard both in favor and against, and in the end BBA and BWNA voted to support and PBOT honored that vote. This is a three-month trial run and in early October, the barricades will come down and the street reopened. We will then re-evaluate and reach out to neighbors and business and decide if it is something we want permanently.

The Councilor noted that PBOT has a process that includes neighborhood group support of plaza proposals. Can disparate impacts on immediate neighbors be solved in different ways? Parking limitations can be addressed with parking permit tool. There are some challenges, such as truck movements, that may not be able to be changed. Any permanent solution needs a conversation and discussion with PBOT on how to mitigate concerns and issues.

Q6: City Life Commission: What does that mean to you and what are you working on?

Pirtle-Guiney: “Livability including sustainability, jobs and open space. We are working on a Sustainability Day. As it relates to jobs – we are asking the following questions:

- What does it take to live in the city?
- How can we incentivize people to live in city?

“Personally, I am concerned that as we get denser, what does that mean for our open spaces with less private green space? Does that trigger a need for more public green space? Should we be looking at more pocket parks and walkable neighborhood models?

“Thank you for having me.”

Meeting Minutes for July 13th - Corrections identified by Al, Patti has made them. Motion to adopt corrected meeting minutes made by John, seconded by Crystal and passed unanimously.

Treasurer Report:

- Total - \$29,354.00
- \$28,706.10 checking
- \$647.29 Venmo
- Reimbursement \$173.40 Patti K – Art and Garden; \$225.85 Susan for Block Party Yard Signs; \$105 Sven for street block party permit fee; \$815 reimbursement – event and alcohol permit

NECN UPDATE: NECN Executive Director Jona Davis coming to our BWNA General Meeting October 12th. No NECN Meeting in July.

Board Retreat: Saturday, November 14th at Mule Bar for Clementine Banquet Room: Time to be determined. 9 to 1 preferred, however 11 to 4 may be only option. Waiting for confirmation.

Questions to be Considered for Retreat:

- Should we allow committee chairs to have full participation? In the past deliberations were confined to board members.
- Should we vote on motions at retreat? If yes – then it’s required to be a public meeting. Or do we want to have it as a bonding/planning gathering without voting on any issues?

Speaker for September 14th Meeting: Beth Larson, speaking about BW and Alameda Neighborhood Emergency (NET) Team.

Non-Board Member Share: Limit to 3 minutes to talk about any topic

- Jim Karlock: Topic – Density: Metro Ballot passed 3:1 demonstrating people were against increasing density. 2012 re-ran the same question, and again, 3:1 voted to not ~~want to~~ push density. The old airplane factory – at 33rd and Broadway (the long-time home of Gordon's Fireplace) – sits vacant with redevelopment stalled due to city making excessive demands. Centennial Mills did not redevelop from same issue and recently burned. Elected officials need to be held accountable. Recently the city paid out \$750k to a property owner because the city refused to allow them to take out a dead tree that later fell on their home.
- Michael Taylor– Oregon author and historian: Shared trends he sees in regards to street renaming process. If interested in his weekly topics – can sign up for his newsletter. Hand-out provided of newsletter on street name change topic.

Non-BW Sponsored Community Event Updates:

- **NAKED BIKE RIDE:** Susan Trabucco reporting. Joyous, quiet, organized. Did not impact her neighborhood as far as she could see. The route went from Skidmore to Mason and moved quickly through BW. Participants had great time. People respectful. Will be covered in newsletter. Al Ellis noted that the organizers came to an earlier BWNA meeting to answer questions. Park was cleaned up.
- **FREMONT FEST:** BWNA had a booth. Matt and Crystal Grainger reported it was a positive experience, met neighbors, had great time. Feedback & observations: 1) When people met us last year – saw flags and came and wanted to learn more about organization. This year people came to play guessing game with fewer people interested in learning more about BWNA. Suggest changing to guessing game focused on BWNA activities. 2) Woman who volunteered at booth did not know what to say. Suggest volunteers get orientation and have speaking points or “elevator pitch”. Tim Gillespie noted that there was a lost child and unclear what to do. Suggest BBA set something up for managing lost children – location of where to find lost child?

Al Ellis – Reported neighbor from 45th came by to express concerns on plaza. Al thanked Matt for figuring out the button to get the canopy up and down.

Committee Updates:

- **New Home Owner Packets** – Al Ellis Reporting: Some addresses identified as BW were on Alameda side of 33rd. Alameda now has their own welcome program so deferred to them. Four packets left needing delivery. Volunteers requested.

- **Events Committee** – John Reporting:

Block Party September 11th: Additional \$500 needed in addition to \$3,500 already approved in budget. Costs for barricades and lights have gone up. This year they also had to get an alcohol permit for free beer samples given out. In past it was understood these were allowed but 12

oz. beers not considered samples, therefore permit required. The event currently has \$2,600 in sponsorships, so additional costs should be covered.

John made motion to increase budget for Block Party by \$500 and Crystal seconded. Motion passed unanimously.

Art and Garden Tour 2026: Event is estimated to net \$3,500. Feedback Received: Up the game on the gardens, they were not “up to snuff”. Suggest map to use showing garden locations. People shared they enjoyed interacting with neighbors by participating in the event.

John’s granddaughter also made \$220 on cookie sales 😊

Movie in Park: Thursday, August 13th, John will do BWNA intro.

Yard Sale: Success with people reporting increased traffic by participating in group event.

Volunteer Recognition: Previously approved \$300 for merchandise. If baseball hats purchased could cost \$750 depending on graphics and quantity. Graphic shared for BWNA hats that will be for sale. John made motion to approve graphic and Susan seconded. Motion passed unanimously.

Missoula Flood Presentation: October 29th.

Neighborhood Clean-up: Coordinating with Beaumont Middle School for clean-up.

Traffic Island- Wisteria: Neighbor who takes care of the island is ill and needs others to take over. Volunteers requested.

- **Transportation Committee:** Graeme Rudd reported that he has scheduled time with the PBOT liaison that past Transportation Committee Chair Colin O’Neill had. Met with public affairs liaison too. Objective to get a clear picture of what is happening in the neighborhood. Need more data to understand what is happening. Graeme’s background is a data scientist and attorney. Fremont is designated a high crash corridor for cars, cyclists and pedestrians. Intersection reports do not provide a clear picture of what data is in neighborhood. Timely updates needed. Graeme also worked for federal government for 14 years and sees potential to seek federal dollars for aspirational goals. City Council wants to see pedestrian cross walks within 100 feet of every bus stop. Need to complete a census or inventory of cross walks and determine what is needed to implement plan. How do we unlock dollars for projects? Schools – PBOT Safe Routes to School program. Federal Clean Energy Fund – funds available for schools and safety.

Concern from Karla Lenox and Peggy Ellis: Candle sticks in street (knocked over) – not being dealt with by the city: 33rd and Mason – 5 down, 4 on concrete. Skidmore and 33rd – one missing.

Patty Nelson— recommends asking how we can be engaged earlier in process for project development. See if we can partner and help pursue alternative funding to fund scope that meets city objectives and neighborhood input/needs.

- **PLAZA Ad Hoc Committee:** Aaron Breakstone fielding concerns at bwnaplaza.org - neighborhood can be made aware of the feedback. Meeting next Monday on the Plaza. One event scheduled. How do we let people know how to schedule? Request was made for board to receive report of all comments received to date. Al Ellis asks for report for next board meeting. Susan Trabucco comments that feedback would be too late for inclusion in newsletter.
- **Newsletter** – Susan reports that feedback on plaza will not be in time for newsletter. She had hoped to include that information. Two more advertisers, both painting contractors, were secured. 36% revenue. \$575 revenue this issue.
- **Communications Committee:** Steve Avery reported the redesigned website is ready for testing. The committee will meet this month and review. When the committee approves design, they will bring to board for approval. The goal is September. Steve will send link to new website to board to review ahead of board meeting. Discussed sending survey out seeking input for Community Updates.
- **Crime & Safety Committee:** Patty reported she would follow-up on car thefts and house break ins and reminded everyone that when this occurred last year, people were encouraged to not leave anything in their cars and to ensure they are locked.
- **Land-Use and Friends of Wilshire Park:** No report.

Meeting adjourned 8:40 pm